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Introducing Anthropology and its Subject Matter

1.1 Definition, Scope and Subject Matter of Anthropology

1.1.1 Concepts in Anthropology

- **Etymology:** compound of two Greek words
 - **Anthropos** - human being/mankind
 - **Logos** - reason/study/science
- Therefore it is **reason about humans** or the study or science of humankind or humanity
- Unlike other disciplines Anthropology is the **study of people—their origins, their development, and contemporary variations**, wherever and whenever they have been found
- **man** has **two important characteristics: biological and cultural** which are **inseparable elements**
- It is dedicated to the comparative study of **humans as a group**
- **anthropology** is a **science** which
 - **Investigates the strategies for living** that are **learned and shared by people** as members of human social groups
 - Examines the **characteristics** that **human beings share** as members of one species (*homo sapiens*) and the **diverse ways** that people **live in different environments**

- Analyses the **products of social groups** -material objects (**material cultures**) and **non-material creations** (religion/beliefs, social values, institutions, practices, etc)
- tries to achieve an **understanding** of **culture**, **society** and **humanity** through detailed studies of community life, supplemented by comparison
- Its **ultimate goal** is to **develop** an integrated picture of **humankind**
- anthropology primarily offers **two kinds of insight**
 1. produces **knowledge** about the **actual biological and cultural variations** in the world
 2. offers **methods and theoretical perspectives** enabling the practitioner to **explore, compare, understand** and **solve** these **varied expressions** of the human condition

1.1.2 The Historical Development of Anthropology

- anthropology is a **fairly recent discipline**
- has important forerunners in the historiography, geography, travel writing, philosophy and jurisprudence of earlier times
- considered as the **science of humanity**
- **originated** in three or four '**Western**' countries: **France**, **Great Britain**, the **USA** and, until the Second World War, **Germany**
- Historically speaking, this **is a European discipline**
- has its **roots in** the works and ideas of the great **ancient** and **Medieval** Greek, Roman, and Hebrew **philosophers** and **social thinkers**
- as an **academic discipline** was born during the **19th century**, **out of** the intellectual atmosphere of **Enlightenment**: eighteenth century social philosophical movement
- the late **1870s**, anthropology was beginning to **emerge as a profession**

- major **impetus for its growth** was the **expansion of western colonial powers** and their consequent **desire to better understand the peoples living under colonial domination**
- Early anthropologists mainly studied small communities in **technologically simple societies: traditional, non-industrialized**
- In **Ethiopia**, professional anthropologists have been studying culture and society on a more intensive level **only since** the late **1950s**

1.1.3 Scope and subject matter of anthropology

- The breadth and depth of anthropology is immense: covers the past, the present and even the future
- covers **all aspects of human ways of life experiences and existence**, as humans live in a social group
- anthropology studies **humanity** with its all aspects of **existence**, and in its all means of differences (**diversity**) and similarities (**commonality**)
- crucial part of the anthropological project consists in conceptualizing and understanding similarities between social systems and human relationships
- try to understand both connections **within societies** and connections **between societies**
- Anthropologists strive for an understanding of the biological and cultural origins and evolutionary development of the species
- **concerned with all humans, both past and present: their behavior patterns, thought systems, material possessions.**
- in the broadest sense, anthropology aims to describe **what it means to be human**

1.2 Sub-fields of anthropology

- anthropology has often categorized into **four major subfields:**

1) Physical/Biological Anthropology

- Unlike comparative biologists, physical anthropologists study how culture and environment have influenced biological evolution and contemporary variations
 - ✓ Human biology affects/explains some aspects of behavior, society, and culture like marriage patterns, sexual division of labor, gender ideology etc
 - ✓ culture in turn have biological effects like the standards of attractiveness, food preferences, and human sexuality, biological variations such as morphology/structure, color, and size
- major sources of biological variations are derived from the interrelated effects of natural selection, geographical isolation, genetic mutations
- Physical anthropology is essentially concerned with two broad areas of investigation:
 - human evolution
 - study of the gradual processes of simple forms into more differentiated structures in hominid
 - interested in reconstructing the evolutionary record of the human species using fossils/bones
 - divided into specialties
 - 1. Paleoanthropology
 - “paleo” meaning “old”
 - analysis of fossil remains from prehistoric times to determine the missing link that connect modern human with its biological ancestors
 - 2. Primatology

- studies about primates or recent human ancestors
- study the anatomy and social behavior of such non-human primate species as gorillas and chimpanzees

➤ Human genetics

- investigate how and why the physical traits of contemporary human populations vary throughout the world
- examine genetic materials such as DNA and RNA
- genetic studies are crucial in understanding how evolution works and plays important role in identifying the genetic source of some hereditary disease like sickle cell anemia and cystic fibrosis

2) Archaeological Anthropology

- studies the ways of lives of past peoples by excavating and analyzing the material culture/physical remains they left behind

➤ Artefacts

- ✓ material remains made and used by the past peoples
- ✓ can be removed from the site and taken to the laboratory for further analysis
- ✓ Example: Tools, ornaments, arrowheads, coins, and fragments of pottery

➤ Features

- ✓ are like artifacts, are made or modified by past people
- ✓ BUT they cannot be readily carried away from the site

- ✓ Example: house foundations, ancient buildings, fireplaces, steles, and postholes

➤ Eco-facts

- ✓ non- artificial, organic and environmental remains
- ✓ were not made or altered by humans; but were used by them
- ✓ Example: soil, animal bones, and plant remains
- ✓ provide archaeologists with important data concerning the environment and how people used natural resources in the past

- Archaeology has also its own subfields or areas of specialties. The most important ones are

➤ Prehistoric archaeology

- investigates human prehistory and prehistoric cultures
- focuses on entire period between 6,000 years ago and the time of the first stone tools (the first artifacts) around 2.5 million years ago

➤ Historic archaeologists

- reconstruct the cultures of people who used writing and about whom historical documents have been written
- takes advantage of the fact that about 6,000 years ago

3) Linguistic Anthropology

- studies human language as a cultural resource and speaking as a cultural practice in its social and cultural context, across space and time
- focuses on the evolution of languages
- tries to understand languages variation in their structures, units, and grammatical formations

- gives **special attention** to the study of **unwritten languages**
- Language is basically a system of information transmission and reception & a key to explore a culture
- Humans communicate messages by
 - **sound (speech)**
 - **gesture (body language)**
 - other **visual ways** such as writing
- languages hand down **cultural traits** from one generation to another
- language is the most **distinctive feature of being human**
- Linguistic anthropology studies contemporary human languages as well as those of the past
- It is divided into four distinct branches or areas of research:
 - **Structural /Descriptive Linguistics**
 - studies the **structure of linguistic patterns**
 - examines **sound systems, grammatical systems,** and the **meanings** attached to words in specific languages
 - aim to understand the structure and **set of rules** of given language; to compile **dictionaries and grammar books** for previously **unwritten languages**
 - thousands of human languages, at least **structurally all of them are similar** making it possible for everyone of us to grasp and learn languages
 - **Ethno-linguistics (cultural linguistics)**
 - examines the **relationship between language and culture**
 - explore how different linguistic categories can affect how people **categorize their experiences,**

how they think, and how they perceive the world around them

➤ Historical linguistics

- deals with the emergence of language in general and how specific languages have diverged over time
- focuses on comparison and classifications of different languages to differentiate the historical links between them

➤ Socio-linguistics

- investigates linguistic variation within a given language
- No language is a homogeneous system
- reason for variation is geography
- Linguistic variation also is expressed in the bilingualism of ethnic groups

4) Socio-Cultural Anthropology

- the largest sub-fields of anthropology
- deals with human society and culture
- describes, analyzes, interprets, and explains social, cultural and material life of contemporary human societies
- engage in two aspects of study

➤ Ethnography

- ✓ based on field work
- ✓ provides a comprehensive account of a particular community, society, or culture
- ✓ detailed descriptions (ethnographies) are the result of extensive field studies (usually a year or two, in duration)
- ✓ anthropologist observes, talks to, and lives with the people he or she is studying

➤ Ethnology

- ✓ based on cross-cultural comparison, Uses data collected by a series of researchers
- ✓ comparative study of contemporary cultures and societies
- ✓ examines, interprets, analyzes, and compares the results of ethnography the data gathered in different societies
- ✓ ethnologists attempt to identify and explain cultural differences and similarities, to test hypotheses, and to build theory to enhance our understanding of how social and cultural systems work
- ✓ primary objective of ethnology is to uncover general cultural principles, the “rules” that govern human behavior.
- ✓ It is usually synthetic
- sub-divided into many other specialized fields as: Anthropology of Art, Medical Anthropology, Urban Anthropology, Economic Anthropology etc

1.3 Unique (Basic) Features of Anthropology

- characteristics that identify anthropology from other discipline
 - a broad scope
 - ✓ Anthropology is the broad study of human kind, around the world and throughout time
 - its approach
 - ✓ anthropology is holistic, relativistic, and focused
 - Holistic: it looks any phenomena from different vantage points
 - considers culture, history, language and biology essential to a complete understanding of society

- **relativity**: is highly appreciated in anthropological studies
 - tries to study and **explain** a certain belief, practice or institution of a group of people in **its own context**
 - does not make value judgment
- **Focusing more on the local than the big social processes** has been another **exclusive approach** in the discipline
 - Pay **great attention to local or micro-social processes** certainly help us to better understand big changes in societies
- ✓ Anthropology's **comparative perspective** helps to understand **differences and similarities across time and place**
- ✓ Considers **insiders' views**: how people **perceive themselves and understand their world**
 - This is what anthropologists call **emic perspective**
 - the logic and justification behind group behavior and cultural practices
- ✓ **highly dependent on qualitative research** to understand the meaning behind any human activity
- ✓ **Extended fieldwork, participant observation, in-depth and key informant interviews and focus-group discussion** are qualitative research instruments

1.4 Misconceptions about anthropology

- **Misconception 1: anthropology is limited to the study of "primitive" societies**

- However, anthropologists nowadays study most advanced and most complex societies as well
- Misconception 2: anthropologists only study the rural people and rural areas
 - But now, anthropologists are also interested in the study of urban people and urban areas. There is a distinct sub-discipline devoted to the study of urban societies called - Urban Anthropology
- Misconception 3: it is wrongly misconceived that anthropology is the study/analysis of fossil evidences of the proto-humans
 - doesn't mean that anthropology is all about the study of human evolution
- Misconception 4: It is misconceived that the purpose of anthropology is to study in order to keep and preserve communities far from development and obsolete cultural practices in museums
 - Rather, anthropologists' duties are to support those communities' capacity to empower themselves in development processes
 - assist peoples' initiatives instead of imposed policies and ideas

1.5 The Relationship between Anthropology and Other Disciplines

- similar with other social sciences such as sociology, psychology, political sciences, economics, history, etc
- greatly overlaps with these disciplines that study human society
- differs from other social sciences and the humanities by its
 - broad scope
 - ✓ anthropology studies humankind in its entirety

- **unique approach**
 - ✓ approach, anthropology studies and analyzes human ways of life **holistically**, **comparatively** and in a **relativistic manner**
- **perspective**
 - ✓ The perspective is **fundamentally empirical**, **naturalistic** and **ideographic** [particularizing] than **nomothetic** [universalizing] one
- **method of research**
 - ✓ it is unique in that it **undertakes extended fieldwork**
 - ✓ develops **intimate knowledge** of the life and social worlds of **its study group/society**
- **unit of analysis**

1.6 The Contributions of anthropology

- Anthropology has **established** for itself the **task of examining all aspects of humanity for all periods of time and for all parts of the globe**
- its contributions are immense. By studying anthropology, we get the following benefits
 - the **anthropological perspective**
 - ✓ its emphasis on the comparative study of cultures, should lead us to the conclusion that:
 - **our culture is just one way of life among many found in the world** and that it represents one way (among many possible ways) to adapt to a particular set of environmental conditions
 - Through the process of contrasting and comparing, we gain a fuller understanding of other cultures and our own
 - **gives us an insight into different ways and modes of life of human society** (social and cultural diversity)

- helps to understand the logic and justification behind group behavior and cultural practices
- let us know how our everyday decisions are influencing others in a multitude of ways and how others' decisions are also influencing ours
- cultural anthropology offers a unique perspective on how local cultural groups are engaging with the process of globalization
- Because of its relativistic approach, anthropology helps us to be more sensitive to and appreciative of cultural diversity and variability
- helps us fight against prejudice and discriminations. It helps us fight against **ethnocentrism**: the belief that one's own culture and one's own way of life is superior to others cultural, social and material life, arises from ignorance about other ethnic groups and their ways of lives
- used as a tool for development. Paying attention to local conditions, is crucial to solve community problems
- In general, anthropology is able to suggest sound solutions to all things human E.g areas of Environmental Change, Health and Nutrition, Globalization, Social Justice etc

END OF CHAPTER 1

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Human Culture and Ties that Connect

2.1. Conceptualizing Culture: What Culture is and What Culture isn't

Definition of Culture

- Edward B. Tylor
 - ✓ a complex whole which includes knowledge, belief, art, morals, law, custom, and any other capabilities and habits acquired by man as a member of society
- B. Malinowski
 - ✓ cumulative creation of man
 - ✓ the handiwork of man and the medium through which he achieves his ends.
- Robert Bierstedt
 - ✓ complex whole that consists of everything we think and do and have as members of society
- culture is the common way of life shared by a group of people
- It includes all things beyond nature and biology

- Therefore **Culture is**
 - ✓ **moral, intellectual and spiritual discipline** for advancement, in accordance with the norms and values based on accumulated heritage
 - ✓ a **system of learned behavior** shared by and transmitted among the members of the group
 - ✓ **collective heritage** learned by individuals and passed from one generation to another
- **individual** receives culture as part of social heritage and in turn, may **reshape the culture and introduce changes** which then become part of the heritage of succeeding generations

2.2 Characteristic Features of Culture

Main Features of culture

1. Culture Is Learned

- ✓ It **not transmitted genetically**
- ✓ it is acquired through the process of learning or interacting with one's environment
- ✓ human relies for their survival on behavior patterns that are learned
- ✓ **Enculturation:**
 - **process of acquiring culture after we born**
 - the process by which an individual learns the rules and values of one's culture

2. Culture Is Shared

- ✓ Thing, idea, behavior pattern to qualify as being “cultural” it must have a shared meaning by at least two people within a society
- ✓ In order to society to operate effectively, guidelines must be shared by its members
- ✓ Without shared culture
 - Members unable to communicate and cooperates
 - confusion and disorder world result

3. Culture Is Symbolic

- ✓ A symbol is something verbal or nonverbal, within a particular language or culture that comes to stand for something else
- ✓ Symbolic thought is unique and crucial to humans and to cultural learning
- ✓ There need be no obvious, natural, or necessary connection between the symbol and what it symbolizes
- ✓ symbol’s meaning is not always obvious
- ✓ many symbols are powerful and often trigger behaviors or emotional states
 - ✓ Example: the designs and colors of the flags

4. Culture Is All-Encompassing

- ✓ It encompasses all aspects(material and non-material), which affect people in their everyday lives
- ✓ particular people’s culture referring to all of its man- made objects, ideas, activities, old time things or those created lately
- ✓ Culture It is the sum total of human creation: intellectual, technical, artistic, physical, and moral
- ✓ It is the complex pattern of living that directs human social life

5. Culture Is Integrated

- ✓ Cultures are **not haphazard** collections of customs and beliefs
- ✓ It is integrated wholes, the **parts** of which, to some degree, are **interconnected** with one another
- ✓ A **culture is a system**, change in one aspect will likely **generate changes in other aspects**
- ✓ We can describe integrated nature of culture is by using the analogy between a culture and a living organism
 - ❖ human body comprises a number of systems, all functioning to maintain the overall health of the organisms

6. Culture Can Be Adaptive and Maladaptive

- ✓ Humans have both **biological and cultural ways of coping with environmental stresses**
- ✓ we use "cultural adaptive kits," which contain customary activities and tools that aid us
- ✓ unlike other animals, **people adapt to the environment & any ecological condition using culture**
- ✓ Culture has allowed the global human population to grow in population through out the long history
- ✓ Sometimes, adaptive behaviour that offers short-term benefits to particular subgroups or individuals may harm the environment and threaten the group's long-term survival
 - ✓ Example: driving Automobiles
- ✓ Many cultural patterns such as **overconsumption and pollution** appear to be **maladaptive** in the long run

7. Culture Is Dynamic

- ✓ Culture is **changing constantly** as new ideas and new techniques are added

- ✓ There are **no cultures that remain completely static** year after year
- ✓ This characteristics of culture **stems from the culture's cumulative quality**

2.3 Aspects/Elements of Culture

Two of the most basic aspects of culture are:

1) Material culture

- consist of **man-made objects**
 - ✓ such as: tools, implements, furniture, automobiles, buildings, physical substance which has been changed and used by man
- It is concerned with the **external, mechanical and utilitarian objects.**
- It is referred to as **civilization**

2) Non – Material culture

- The term 'culture' when used in the ordinary sense, means 'non-material culture'
- It is something **internal and intrinsically valuable**, **reflects the inward nature of man**
- consists of:
 - ✓ words, language
 - ✓ beliefs, values and virtues
 - ✓ habits, rituals and practices, ceremonies
 - ✓ customs and tastes, attitudes & outlook, our ways of acting, feeling and thinking
- Some of the aspects of non-material culture

➤ Values

- standards by which member of a society define what is good or bad, beautiful or ugly
- central aspect of the nonmaterial culture of a society
- important because they influence the behavior of the members of a society.

➤ Beliefs

- cultural conventions that concern true or false assumptions, specific descriptions of the nature of the universe and humanity's place in it

❖ Values are generalized notions of what is good and bad; beliefs are more specific and, in form at least, have more content, example:

- ✓ Education is good – value
- ✓ Grading is the best way to evaluate students - belief

➤ Norms

- shared rules or guidelines that define how people “ought” to behave under certain circumstances
- They are generally connected to the values, beliefs, and ideologies of a society
- Norms vary in terms of their importance to a culture, these are:

1. Folkway

- Norms guiding ordinary usages and conventions of everyday life
- They are norms that are not strictly enforced

- Example: not leaving your seat for an elderly people inside a bus/taxi – result - a person getting a bad look

2. Mores

- **much stronger norms** than are folkways
- They are norms that are believed to be essential to core values and we insist on conformity
- Example: Steals, rapes, kills - violation are society's most important mores
- **People who violate mores are usually severely punished**, although **punishment for the violation of mores varies from society to society**, It may take the form of
 - ✓ Ostracism, vicious gossip, public ridicule, exile, loss of one's job, physical beating, imprisonment, commitment to a mental asylum, or even execution

2.4 Cultural Unity and Variations: Universality, Generality and Particularity of Culture

- i. Certain biological, psychological, social, and cultural features are
 - **Universal** - found in **every culture**
 - **Generalities** - common to **several but not all** human groups
 - **Particularities** - **unique** to certain cultural traditions

1) Universality

- cultural traits that **span across all cultures**
- **Most are biologically** that distinguish us from other species
 - ✓ Long period of infant dependency, Year-round sexuality, Complex brain that enables use of symbols, languages, and tools Social universals, Life in groups
 - ✓ A great **example** of universality is – **family**

2) Generality

- traits that **occur in many societies but not all of them**
- Societies can share same beliefs and customs because of **borrowing Domination (colonial rule)**
 - ✓ when customs and procedures are imposed on one culture can also cause generality Independent innovation of same cultural trait – Farming
 - ✓ **Examples - Nuclear family Parents and children**

3) Particularity

- Trait of a culture that is **not widespread** Cultural borrowing
 - ✓ traits once limited are more widespread Useful traits that don't clash with current culture get borrowed
- **Examples: – Food dishes**
- Particularities are becoming **rarer in some ways but also becoming more obvious**
- Borrowed cultural traits are modified Marriage, parenthood, death, puberty, birth all celebrated differently

2.5. Evaluating Cultural Differences: Ethnocentrism, Cultural Relativism and Human Rights

The concepts of ethnocentrism and cultural relativism occupy key position in anthropology

I. ETHNOCENTRISM

- It refers to the tendency to see the behaviors, beliefs, values, and norms of **one's own group as the only right way of living** and to judge others by those standards
- operate on the premise that our own society's ways are the correct, normal, better ways, for acting, thinking, feeling and behaving
 - ✓ **Our own group is the centre or axis of everything**, and we scale and rate all others with reference to it
- It is a cultural universal
- **Alien cultural traits are often viewed as being not just different but inferior, less sensible, and even "unnatural".**
- **Ethnocentrism results in:**
 - **prejudices** about people from other cultures and the rejection of their "alien ways."
 - **prevent** us from **understanding and appreciating** another culture
 - **prevent open communication** and **result in misunderstanding and mistrust**
- The **positive aspect of ethnocentrism:**
 - the **protection that it can provide for a culture**. By causing a rejection of the foods, customs, and

perceptions of people in other cultures, it acts as a **conservative force** in preserving traditions of one's own culture

II. CULTURAL RELATIVISM

- The concept of cultural relativism states that cultures differ, so that a **cultural trait, act, or idea has no meaning but its meaning only within its cultural setting**
- A **culture has to be studied in terms of its own meanings and values**
 - we need to examine others behavior as insiders, seeing it **within the framework of their values, beliefs and motives**
 - Cultural relativism suspends judgment and views about the behavior of people **from the perspective of their own culture**
- Cultural relativism describes a situation where **there is an attitude of respect for cultural differences** rather than condemning other people's culture as uncivilized or backward
- Respect for cultural differences involves:
 - ✓ **Appreciating cultural diversity**, Accepting and **respecting** other cultures
 - ✓ Knowing that a person's own culture is only one among many;
 - ✓ **Recognizing** that what is immoral, ethical, acceptable, etc, **in one culture may not be so in another culture.**

III. HUMAN RIGHTS

- Human rights are rights based on justice and morality beyond and superior to particular countries, cultures, and religions
- Such rights are seen as inalienable (nations cannot abridge or terminate them) and international (larger than and superior to individual nations and cultures)
- The idea of human rights challenges cultural relativism by invoking a realm of justice and morality beyond and superior to the laws and customs of particular countries, cultures, and religions
- Anthropologists respect human diversity. Most ethnographers try to be objective, accurate, and sensitive in their accounts of other cultures. However, their objectivity, sensitivity and a cross-cultural perspective got nothing to do with ignoring international standards of justice and morality

2.6 Culture Change

- anthropological account of the culture of any society is a type of snapshot view of one particular time
- there are no cultures that remain completely static year after year

Culture change can occur as a result of the following Mechanisms:

1) Diffusion

- The process by which cultural elements are borrowed from another society and incorporated into the culture of the recipient group

- Culture change can occur as a result of the following Mechanisms:
 - Direct
 - ✓ when two cultures **trade** with, **intermarry** among, or wage **war** on one another
 - Forced
 - ✓ when **one culture subjugates another and imposes its customs** on the dominated group
 - Indirect
 - ✓ when items or traits move from group A to group C via group B **without any firsthand contact** between A and C
 - group B might be traders or merchants
 - group B might be geographically situated between A and C
- ❖ In today's world, much international diffusion is indirect-culture spread by the **mass media** and advanced information technology

2) Acculturation

- When exchange of cultural features results groups **having continuous firsthand contact**
- This usually happens in situations of **trade or colonialism**
- In situations of **continuous contact**, cultures have also exchanged and blended foods, recipes, music, dances, clothing, tools, and technologies

3) Invention

- Invention is the process by which humans innovate, creatively finding solutions to problems

- people in different societies have innovated and changed in similar ways, which is one reason cultural generalities exist
- Often a major invention, such as agriculture, triggers a series of subsequent interrelated changes
 - ✓ example is the independent invention of agriculture in the Middle East and Mexico
 - It led to many social, political, and legal changes

4) Globalization

- The term globalization encompasses a series of processes, including diffusion and acculturation, working to promote change in a world in which nations and people are increasingly interlinked and mutually dependent
 - ✓ Promoting such linkages are economic and political forces, as well as modern systems of transportation and communication
- The mass media help propel a globally spreading culture of consumption
- Emigrants transmit information and resources transnationally, as they maintain their ties with home. In a sense such people live multilocally-in different places and cultures at once

